

KF Introduction to NHG

Chapter 11: *Resignation*¹

This is our last study session of *Neurosis and Human Growth*. Dr. Horney has uncovered for us the basic problem of neurosis, which affects everything we think, feel, and do, and you might be asking yourself, “What do I do now? How can I grow out of neurosis and start living a more productive, healthier, happier life? How can I align my life with God’s plans and purposes?” Karis Fellowships is a training program that has helped many people redirect their lives away from pride, fear, conflict, and strain. If you want to grow into your potential in Christ, you may wish to train with a community of believers who are working to do just that!

In chapter 11, Dr. Horney describes the neurotic solution of resignation. The Bible gives us several examples of this neurotic type. In the book of First Samuel, we are introduced to the high priest, Eli. When Eli sees Hannah fervently praying in the temple, he reacts to her strong feelings with criticism and irritation. Perhaps he saw in her a passion for God that he knew did not exist within himself. Her strong feelings scared him, but God responded to Hannah’s faith by granting her request. Hannah’s active trust is a strong contrast to Eli’s passivity. Eli knew that his sons, who were priests, were behaving in a reprehensible way, but he made no effort to correct or restrain them, and God rebuked him for his inaction. Eli never asked God how to deal with this situation because he didn’t want to know. Knowing might bring with it obligations, and obligation is something the resigned neurotic wants to avoid at all costs. In the end, Eli died from his own inertia (1 Sam. 4:18).

Isaac, the father of Esau and Jacob, also took refuge in resignation. He could not see the turmoil going on around him because he did not want to see it. He refused to take responsibility for his family’s conflicts and was unwilling to help those around him find solutions. By habitually refusing to engage with his own life, he obligated others to take on his responsibilities. Isaac was only interested in maintaining his own comfortable routines and remaining free from imposition. It is, therefore, not surprising that his wife learned to act on her own initiative. She knew that her husband could only be relied upon to do nothing.

Isaac passed his resigned attitude and habits on to his eldest son, Esau. Even though Esau had a flash of remorse over the results of his decision to sell his birthright, prosperity allowed him to escape the immediate consequences of his choices. He eventually drifted back into non-engagement. When we read about Esau, we never see him make any effort to grow into a man whom God could trust. Even his grudge against his brother Jacob became an imposition that required too much effort to sustain. He eventually invited Jacob back into a jolly, generous relationship that did not require any growth or personal development. Jacob, however, was wise enough to see that Esau’s unwillingness to actively engage with God made his brother untrustworthy.

When Jesus was in the wilderness, the devil tempted Him with the solution of resignation, saying, “Turn these stones into bread”— in other words, “Don’t make life harder than it need be. Look after number one and you will be completely free to do what you like. If you don’t depend on anyone, they won’t depend on you.” He invited Jesus to take the easy way out by enticing Him to reject the obligations and difficulties of His mission and, instead, to pursue autonomous freedom. Many resigned people work hard to gain financial freedom or plod away at careers that promise a long and comfortable retirement. They are sustained by the illusion that they can live a life of complete freedom without ever having to change.

Many people in our modern culture are resigned and appear to be undisturbed by the complex problems that Dr. Horney describes. However, underneath their placid exterior, they are driven by chronic anxiety, which often explodes into unreasonable reactions and hostility. Any form of imposition, whether from others or from within themselves, feels like a threat.

The ability of healthy resigned types to stand immovable and pursue their own path can, however, support God's purposes and glory. Their commitment to self-preservation and autonomy demonstrates to other types what healthy boundaries look like. These boundaries help us guard the real self against our neurotic tendency to dissipate resources. Supported by the dynamics of a trustworthy community and a growing connection with God, resigned types can allow their defensive walls to be transformed into healthy, functioning boundaries that will allow them to fearlessly contribute their substantial gifts to the world.

¹ Karen Horney, *Neurosis and Human Growth* (New York: Norton, 1991).